

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

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DJIA 46946.41 ▲ 387.94 0.83% NASDAQ 22374.18 ▲ 1.2% STOXX 600 598.47 ▲ 0.4% 10-YR. TREAS. ▲ 17/32, yield 4.219% OIL \$93.50 ▼ \$5.21 GOLD \$4,994.00 ▼ \$58.50 EURO \$1.1507 YEN 159.05

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **For the fifth year** running, Fed officials find themselves expecting inflation to fall back to their 2% goal only to be confronted with a new disruption that complicates the path to it. **A1**
- ◆ **A modest decline in oil** prices helped to lift the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow by 1%, 1.2% and 0.8%, respectively, in what some investors described as a relief rally. **B9**
- ◆ **Workers at a critical** beef-processing plant owned by JBS went on strike, stifling production at a time when prices for the meat are at record highs. **B1**
- ◆ **Warner Bros. CEO Zaslav** stands to collect over \$800 million in severance and other pay after Paramount acquires the company. **B1**
- ◆ **UniCredit increased** pressure to take over Commerzbank, a bid opposed by the German government, which owns 12% of the target lender. **B1**
- ◆ **Nebius agreed to a** five-year deal valued at about \$27 billion to supply artificial-intelligence infrastructure capacity to Meta Platforms. **B4**
- ◆ **Dollar Tree issued** a cautious outlook for the year amid tariff and freight-cost uncertainty, even as demand for discretionary products remains strong. **B3**
- ◆ **Public Storage agreed** to acquire National Storage Affiliates in a \$5.63 billion all-stock deal, creating a company with a combined market capitalization of about \$57 billion. **B3**
- ◆ **Foxconn reported** double-digit growth in annual net profit and expects continued robust demand for its artificial-intelligence servers in 2026. **B4**

Worldwide

- ◆ **Iran's rulers unleashed** a new crackdown against domestic dissent, including death threats directed at would-be protesters to deter any popular uprising. **A1**
- ◆ **Germany rejected** Trump's call for allied help to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and Australia and Japan demurred, resisting being drawn into hostilities against Iran. **A1**
- ◆ **Iran appears to be** allowing select ships through the strait, freeing a trickle of oil that has helped to keep a lid on global energy prices. **A6**
- ◆ **The Supreme Court** will hear arguments on the administration's bid to cut off legal protections for immigrants now allowed to live and work in the U.S. if their home countries are in crisis. **A2**
- ◆ **White House** chief of staff Susie Wiles has been diagnosed with early-stage breast cancer and will undergo treatment while continuing to work, Trump said. **A3**
- ◆ **A federal judge in** Massachusetts blocked the Trump administration from implementing its pared-down list of recommended childhood vaccines. **A3**
- ◆ **Cuba's communist** regime wants to open the island to business from the Cuban-American diaspora in a bid to hold off economic disaster. **A8**
- ◆ **China's economy** started the year on a steady footing, giving leaders more room to try to shift the country toward consumption and away from debt-fueled investment. **A8**
- ◆ **Afghanistan accused** Pakistan of an airstrike on a hospital and said the attack killed at least 400 people. **A8**

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An airliner came in for landing at Dubai on Monday as smoke poured from a fuel tank set ablaze near the airport by an Iranian drone.

Iran's Battered Security Forces Step Up Repression Campaign

Fearing an uprising, rulers launch new arrests and warn of no mercy for dissent

By MARGHERITA STANCATI AND HENNA MOUSSAVI

Iran's rulers unleashed a new crackdown against domestic dissent, arresting people suspected of collaborating with foreign entities and threatening would-be protesters with death to hold back the risk of an uprising.

Iranian security forces have been battered by U.S. and Is-

raeli attacks. Bombing raids have shattered the headquarters and command posts of Iran's police, the paramilitary Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps and the plainclothes Basij militia.

But Iranians said security forces are using fear to keep a tight grip on the streets. Armed men ride around on motorcycles brandishing their weapons to intimidate people, residents said, particularly at night, when city dwellers rarely leave their homes.

The men, usually in plainclothes and with their faces covered, also have set up a network of security check-

points around cities like Tehran where they routinely stop and search cars.

At least 500 people have been arrested since the start of the war, facing accusations that include sharing information with international media or with enemy forces with the purpose of helping them identify targets, said Ahmadreza Radan, the commander of Iran's police force, on state television Sunday.

Many were detained for taking photos or videos of sites hit by airstrikes. Others were accused of being monarchists, a reference to supporters of Reza Pahlavi, the exiled son of

Iran's last shah, the most prominent opposition leader abroad. State-run media said 11 suspected monarchists resisted police and were killed.

Among those detained were a mother and her teenage son who are accused of celebrating the killing of Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei, according to Human Rights Activists in Iran, a U.S.-based group that monitors the country. An Israeli strike on Khamenei's compound killed him in the opening salvo of the war.

Several civil society activists were also detained. Among them is Leila Mir Ghaffari, who

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Voter reaction

A Republican stronghold feels war anxiety. **A4**

New front

Israel's ground invasion of Lebanon widens conflict. **A5**

Global economy

Europe gets energy shock it can't afford to absorb. **A5**

Markets

Modest decline in oil prices stems stock slide. **B9**

Heard on the Street

The energy stocks that benefit most from crisis. **B10**

New Shock Hits Fed, Muddling Its Path On Rates

By NICK TIMIRAOS

It's happening again. For the fifth year running, Federal Reserve officials find themselves expecting inflation to fall back to their 2% goal only to be confronted with a new disruption that complicates the path. First it was the pandemic's aftershocks. Then, Russia's war in Ukraine. Last year, a sweeping tariff program.

The most recent data suggested inflation progress stalled even before the U.S.'s war in the Middle East disrupted one of the world's most important shipping routes. The turmoil could send up energy and commodity prices in ways that could further delay reaching the target.

Officials meeting this week face a question that would have seemed unlikely a few months ago: not when they will next cut rates, but whether they can credibly keep telling markets to expect a cut at all.

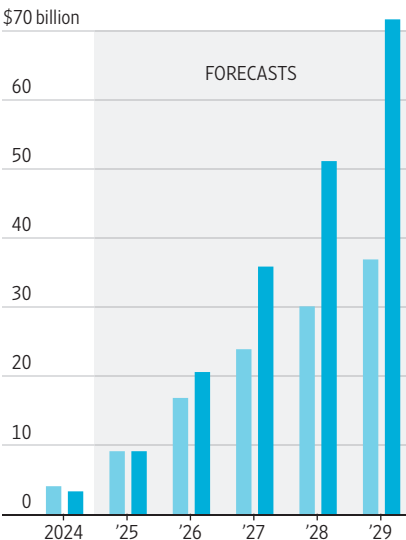
The war is likely to reinforce the consensus around holding rates steady. The harder question is what officials signal beyond the next few months. There are three places to watch:

First is the policy statement. A minority of officials pushed unsuccessfully in January to jettison language hinting that the next move is a cut.

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Global capital spending

■ Training ■ Inference



Note: Data from July 2025
Source: Gartner

Nvidia's Next AI Phase

Nvidia Chief Executive Jensen Huang on Monday unveiled the company's new flagship product aimed at inference, the form of artificial-intelligence computing that allows models to respond to user queries. Customers have asked for better chips that are customized for inference computing, rather than for training. **B1**

At OpenAI, Alarm Over 'Adult Mode'

Company has delayed launch of erotica in ChatGPT, but plans to forge ahead

By SAM SCHECHNER AND GEORGIA WELLS

In January, OpenAI's handpicked council of advisers on well-being and AI met with the company's representatives for an update about a controversial new feature called "adult mode."

Citing the need to "treat adult users like adults," OpenAI Chief Executive Sam Altman had last year floated the

idea of enabling erotic conversation in its ChatGPT chatbot and dropping its ban on such X-rated content.

The plan sparked vigorous debate internally over the potential risks. Council members, with backgrounds in fields like psychology and cognitive neuroscience, had also expressed strong reservations.

Then OpenAI dropped a

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Car Dealers' Nightmare: A Professional Haggler

By IMANI MOISE

February was looking like a slow month for car sales, and Tomi Mikula smelled opportunity.

Sitting in his Harry Potter-themed office near Charlotte, N.C., he picked up the phone and dialed the first of a long string of calls to car dealers. "Hi, I just want to see if you have a car available," he said. "I have the stock number if it's helpful."

On this last business day of the month, he set a goal of closing 30 car purchases for the clients who had hired his firm as their professional negotiator.

Mikula, 33 years old, spent more than a decade selling cars and auto financing at dealerships. Now he deploys his fluency in car-dealer speak

and his encyclopedic knowledge of dealer inventory to try to talk down the sticker prices. Some dealers hate him enough that they won't take his calls. Others relish the chance to go toe-to-toe with a dealmaking foe.

Negotiating a car price has become something of a lost art, but it is one Mikula has become practiced at in the three years since he started his business. For a flat fee of \$1,000, he negotiates on a buyer's behalf. He also livestreams some of his conversations to 600,000 subscribers across TikTok and YouTube.

In Mikula's view, car buying has become so absurd that what he's doing makes perfect sense, even if it is a little offbeat. "You're hiring a middle-

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Scotland's Oldest University Is Packed With Americans

U.S. students love everything about St Andrews—except all the Americans

By JASMINE LI

Holly Govan left New York ready for an adventure abroad at the University of St Andrews in a cobblestone-street town 3,000 miles from home.

Instead, the Upper East Sider got paired with a roommate from lower Manhattan. "Practically every person you hear sounds American," Govan says. "You think you're coming to get this Scottish or international experience, and there's just so many Americans."

The picturesque Scottish university, once the secret of private-school students from the East Coast, now boasts a student body that is about

20% American. With more than 2,200 American students, it beat even Oxford for the highest number of U.S. university expats last year, according to the Higher Education Statistics Agency.

It's not just royal fans wanting to follow in the footsteps of Prince William and Kate Middleton at the 600-year-old campus. Students worn down by the hypercompetitive, expensive American experience are looking overseas, and St Andrews, a top 5 university in the U.K. with a four-year degree structure, often tops the list.

In 2025, applications from U.S. students rose 16.4% from

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